Mom Needs Long-Term Care Now: The First Three Things to Get Onto One Page

Three short summaries, in order, and what can be left for the planning conversation.

Mom is in the facility, this month's statement is on the kitchen table, and the business office, a friend and a website have each told you something different. Everyone is asking what the plan is, and you're still working out where to begin.

Begin with one page. Three short summaries, in this order.

1

Mom's care, in a few lines

Write where Mom is, since when, and what help she gets each day. Medicare.gov describes most long-term care as help with the basic personal tasks of everyday life, such as dressing, bathing and using the bathroom, so name the ones she gets help with. Add the name and phone number of the person at the facility you talk to most. [1]

WHY THIS COMES FIRST Every conversation ahead starts with where Mom is and what she needs. It's also the part you already know best.

2

Her finances, in round numbers

List what comes in each month and from where, what the facility is paid and from which account, and what she owns and owes: accounts, the house, a car, insurance policies, debts. Round numbers are fine, and “don't know yet” is a fair entry. The Consumer Financial Protection Bureau's guide for people managing a relative's money makes the same point: to make careful decisions, you need to know what the person owns and owes. [2]

WHY THIS COMES FIRST The care summary says what Mom needs. This one says what there is to work with, and questions about paying for care are hard to ask without it.

3

What you've been told about Medicaid, and by whom

Write down each thing you've heard about Medicaid so far, who said it, and whether that person knows Mom's situation. Note whether anyone has started an application and, if she is in a nursing home, whether the business office has said it accepts Medicaid payment; Medicare.gov says most, but not all, nursing homes do. Don't try to sort out who is right. [3]

WHY THIS COMES FIRST It rests on the first two, and it's where the advice disagrees. Written down with a name beside each piece, it becomes a list of questions.

Then put the three on one page with the date at the top. That page is what you bring to the planning conversation.

What can be left for the planning conversation

- What stands between Mom's situation today and Medicaid.
- Which of the care, legal, financial and paperwork tasks comes first.
- Who is responsible for each one, in what order, and when to apply.
- Which advice was right. Your page shows where the pieces disagree, and that is enough for now.

One thing to ask about first

If you're asked to sign something, or you're thinking about moving money or property, that is a question to bring first to the professional it belongs to: an elder law attorney, a licensed financial professional or your Medicaid planner. The Consumer Financial Protection Bureau's guide says to get legal advice and be very careful about decisions that may affect a person's eligibility for Medicaid.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't interpret a bill, a notice or a rule, and it doesn't decide anything about Mom's money or her care. Nothing in it is legal, financial or tax advice. It gets three short summaries onto one page.

Ready for the next step?

You've got Mom's care, her finances and what you've been told about Medicaid on one page. The planning interview takes it from there: it asks about your family's situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for care.

Get Your Free Planning Report ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The description of long-term care and the note about nursing homes and Medicaid payment come from Medicare.gov. The advice to know what a person owns and owes, and to get legal advice before decisions that may affect Medicaid eligibility, comes from the Consumer Financial Protection Bureau. The order is ours.

1. Medicare.gov (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), Long-term care
2. Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, Managing someone else’s money: Help for agents under a power of attorney
3. Medicare.gov (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), How can I pay for nursing home care?